

MSI MEGA PC 865 PRO

The MEGA PC 865 PRO is the latest in the series of small form-factor PCs, such as the MEGA 180 and the MEGA 865. On the design front, the MEGA PC 865 PRO has improved significantly, facilitating easy installation of internal components—which was a pain with some of the older models.

The finish is a combination of brushed aluminium and matte-black with orange backlights, giving the MEGA 865 PRO a sedate, classy appeal. The front fascia is split into three horizontal panels. The top panel covers the optical drive, the middle one accommodates the display panel, and the bottom panel covers the various ports—USB, FireWire, sound jacks and the 7-in-1 memory card reader.

The i865G chipset-based motherboard supports an LGA 775 Intel processor up to 3.4 GHz. DDR 400 MHz memory modules in dual mode is supported, but there are just two memory slots. The board offers 5.1 channel sound, which is very good for DVD playback. The graphics subsystem is driven by the onboard Intel graphics offered by the i865 chipset.

One AGP and one PCI slot is provided, which will almost certainly be used for plugging in a TV tuner card, taking into consideration the media centre lineage of this product. You can also opt for wireless connectivity via an optional adapter.

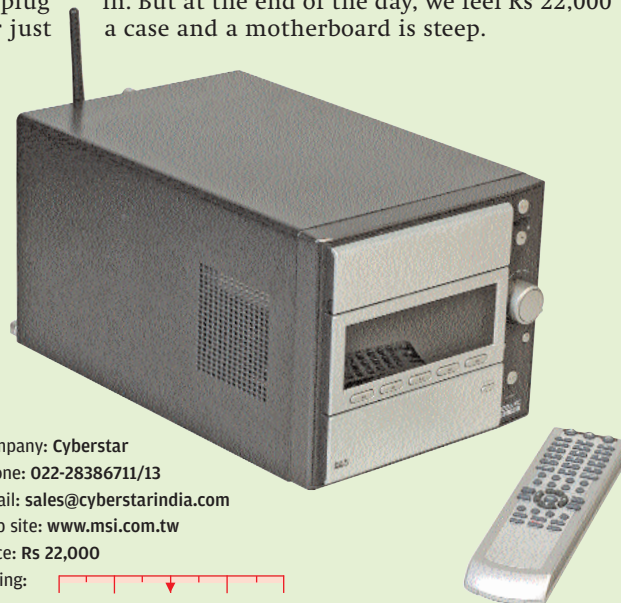
For cooling, the case is provided with an 80 mm fan. The processor is cooled by a combination of a heat pipe and a large heat sink-fan combo.

Extensive manuals make sure you find your way about the installation process.

The MEGA PC 865 PRO has two modes of operation—as an A/V device and as a PC. There are dedicated buttons

for each of these modes. In A/V mode, the device allows you to play FM radio, DVDs, MP3s and TV without booting into the operating system. To enable this functionality, one needs to install the 'InstantOn' software before loading the operating system. Also, it does not support VGA cards as of now.

Overall, the MEGA PC 865 PRO comes across as a well-built product. There are plenty of features—the performance, of course, depends on the hardware you choose to plug in. But at the end of the day, we feel Rs 22,000 for just a case and a motherboard is steep.



Company: Cyberstar
Phone: 022-28386711/13
Email: sales@cyberstarindia.com
Web site: www.msi.com.tw
Price: Rs 22,000
Rating:

AOpen XC Cube AV

The AOpen XC Cube AV is a Small Form Factor (SFF) PC. It is compact, has some really good features, and resembles a portable audio system. The traditional black finish, up-front buttons and large blue LED display accentuate the 'consumer electronics' look.

A large display dominates the front fascia. Menu navigation is achieved by a combination of three buttons beneath the display. Three buttons are placed on either side of the navigation buttons, and they offer the play/pause, forward, reverse and stop functions.

A memory card reader is integrated just above the display panel. The bottom flap covers two USB and two FireWire ports, and the sound card jacks. The back panel has the usual array of ports—two USB, one FireWire, an optical/RCA SPDIF and an RJ45.

Installing components such as processors requires removal of the mounting brackets. This is not a good thing when compared to MSI's MEGA PC, where the mounting cage can be swivelled and locked in position to install components. Moreover, the cables are not properly routed, contrasting with MSI's systematic approach.

The interiors, too, are cramped, and ventilation could be hampered by this. The processor in the XC Cube AV is cooled using just an ordinary, tall-fin heat sink-fan combo. Moreover, the same fan is used for the case ventilation as well and this could be a problem.

The XC Cube AV is sold as a complete solution with all hardware plugged in, for out-of-the-box operation. In fact, a 5.1 speaker set and an anti-RSI wireless keyboard and mouse combo come bundled.

The device we received had a Pentium IV 2.4 GHz processor, 512 MB of DDR 333 MHz RAM, an 80 GB 7200 RPM SATA drive, and an 8X DVD-Writer. A TV tuner card was installed, too!

The XC Cube AV, too, supports two modes of operation. In the first mode, you can use it to play TV, FM radio, MP3s, DVDs, VCDs, etc. without booting the OS. In the other mode it can be used as a regular PC.

The XC Cube set, along with the bells and whistles we've mentioned, is steeply priced at Rs 78,990.

We think this is a little too much. Besides, if you compare it with MSI's MEGA PC 865 PRO, the latter is a more refined product when it comes to component layout, electrical cable routing and ease of installation.



Company: Xserve India (Pvt) Ltd
Phone: 080-51131001
Email: info@xserves.com
Web site: www.xserves.com
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Rating: